I Don’t Want to Have to Kill You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52561663.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

From childhood friends to wartime enemies, Catra and Adora fight each other across the years, and each time things just gets worse and worse.

Scenes takes place before season 1 and during season 2.

Notes

The Graphic Depictions of Violence tag is for chapter 3.

Childhood

Catra's quarterstaff clashed against Lonnie's with a spark of electricity. Lonnie parried several more strikes before she lashed out. Catra caught the blow on her own staff, and raised it to fend off the next one. Lonnie brought her staff around and jabbed it at Catra. Catra went to swerve around it, but the tip of it caught her in the shoulder.

Feigning being hurt, she staggered back and sank to one knee, clutching her shoulder with a snarl of pain she hoped wasn't *too* put on. Lonnie grinned triumphantly, dashing in to finish the job and strike Catra on her training pack, when Catra suddenly ducked right under the blow and hooked Lonnie's leg, sending her to the floor. Lonnie only just managed to roll over when Catra's staff hit her square in the centre, a big red cross appearing on Lonnie's training pack.

Lonnie groaned in frustration, tossing her staff down and crawling away. Catra turned, watching Adora nimbly send Kyle packing by breaking his guard open with one blow and hitting his training pack with the next.

Adora turned to face her, smiling. Catra laughed, twirling her staff.

"Just you left, Adora!"

"Come on, Catra!" Adora laughed too, and ran towards her.

Catra put on an earnest assault, lashing out with her quarterstaff as quick and hard as she could. Adora was on the backfoot at first, but that didn't last, and soon Catra found herself narrowly parrying and ducking under Adora's staff. She jumped backwards and away from another swing, panting heavily.

"Is that all you've got?" she shouted in between her heavy breaths.

Adora came at her again. Catra kept up a desperate defense, but she soon found her feet knocked out from under her, and Adora's staff dashed her training pack the very moment she hit the ground. The screen lit up with a red cross.

"Adora, victor." Cobalt's voice called, and the dark red environment of the training simulation gave way for the familiar interior of the Fright Zone.

Adora offered Catra her hand. Catra grimaced before taking it, letting Adora help her back to her feet.

"Well done, cadets. Put your equipment away, and head on over to your next classes. Dismissed."

The squad saluted him as he marched off, and then everybody surrounded Adora, patting her on the back and congratulating her on winning.

Everybody except Catra, who turned away. Watching them was just too frustrating right now.

But then Adora came up beside her, bumping their shoulders together. "Hey, you did great!"

Catra looked aside at Adora, flashing one of her fangs in a smile of her own. "I nearly had you!"

"Sure you did!" Adora chuckled. "Now come on, we'll be late for histories!"

Adora took Catra by the wrist, and together they ran after the others to the locker room.

After the Battle of Brightmoon

"Rebel outpost in sight, Catra!" Scorpia said. "It's the lighthouse over yonder!"

A huge tidal wave buffeted against the Horde frigate, sending the Horde sailors still in the germinal stages of their sea legs on their asses. Catra gripped the railing of the quarterdeck as she was rocked around, hissing in frustration. She absolutely hated the sea, and *detested* the thought of being sent back into the water like she had been during their previous foray into the Straits.

This is why I should just let Octavia handle this shit.

"Catra! We've got incoming!" Scorpia yelled from her position by the main gun.

"You think!?" Catra grated back, watching the Salinean galleon glide across the waters, propelled by the magic of Princess Mermista. "Fire!"

Scorpia fired off a shot, but the galleon nimbly moved out of the way. A tall figure leapt from the deck of the Salinean ship, sailing gracefully through the air and landing on the Horde frigate with a heavy thud.

"Hey, Adora!" Catra sang out as She-Ra drew herself up, sword brandished fiercely in hand. "Do you like my new ship? I think I'll name it *'The Sea Idiot'* in your honour!"

"Catra," She-Ra returned with half a smile, face set with competitive determination. "You forget what happened last time?"

"Don't worry!" Catra shouted. "That's why I brought a few more toys to play with!" And on cue, two more Horde frigates rounded the bend of the cliffs, their guns all charged up.

Catra took advantage of She-Ra's surprise, pouncing from her perch onto the huge princess' shoulders and raking her claws

down for her face. She-Ra caught the blow on her bracers, throwing Catra off who landed in a fluid crouch by the gun. Scorpia stepped forward, trading several blows on She-Ra's sword before a kick to the centre of her carapace had her sliding across the floor with a grunt.

Catra glanced behind her, seeing the Salinean galleon close as Mermista was casting up another huge tidal wave to assault the Horde ships with. She flashed a cocky smirk at She-Ra, and jumped from the deck of the Horde frigate to the Rebellion ship, darting straight for Mermista.

A heavy thud behind her signaled that Adora was still very much the same: easy to distract and even easier to lead along, always chasing after Catra whenever the opportunity presented itself. Catra increased her speed, slamming her knees into Mermista and kicking the staff from the princess' hands. The coalesced water around the Salinean galleon dispersed, and then Catra was on the princess, clawing away to her heart's content. Mermista tried to fend the blows off, but hand to hand combat was Catra's forté, and the blood was quickly pooling beneath them.

Then She-Ra barreled into Catra's side, sending her rolling across the deck and nearly off into the sea. Catra dug her claws in, casting a worried frown behind her before she refocused her attention on She-Ra.

"Wow, Adora, you're slow," she taunted as she stood up. "Any slower and I'm pretty sure you would've let her kick the bucket."

"I've got her!" Arrow Boy called, running over to tend to Mermista. She-Ra, as Catra predicted, resumed her chase.

Catra let She-Ra chase her around the ship, snaking up the ratlines and around the masts, ever out of the huge woman's reach and keeping up a tirade of taunting. "Is a single ship really all the Rebellion could spare? What, are you planning on setting it on fire again?"

“You can’t keep this up, Catra, just give up!”

“I don’t know, Adora,” Catra said as she leaned nonchalantly against the main mast, pretending to check her claws. “You’re really not making me put in any effort here.”

She-Ra’s huge hand slammed into the wooden mast. Catra dodged it easily; if she hadn’t, she would’ve probably ended up with a concussion, or worse. And Adora probably knew she was gonna dodge it anyway.

Catra didn’t like to think about what might happen if that were to change.

She snaked around the mast, but She-Ra’s hand suddenly closed around the scruff of her tunic, dragging her back and pushing her harshly against the mast.

“Got you. It’s over, Catra.”

Catra blinked the dizziness out of her eyes and smirked up in She-Ra’s face. “Is it?”

She looked aside, and She-Ra followed her gaze. Two of the three Horde frigates had sailed on past the Salinean galleon and were blasting the Rebellion lighthouse to bits.

“No!” She-Ra cried.

“Huh,” Catra grunted, “I guess you’re right.” She brought her knees to her chest and kicked out, freeing herself from She-Ra’s grip and backflipping to the railing. Scorpia was bringing the first frigate around, and Catra hopped aboard as it passed, folding her arms and watching She-Ra rather than the burning ruin of the lighthouse.

“Better luck next time, Adora!”

The War Goes On

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora surveyed the field of battle. It was raining, the dark sky lit up by the exchange of laser fire between the rebels and the endless attack lines of the Horde bots. Behind the robotic suicide charges, more and more tanks were emerging from the treeline of the Whispering Woods, and Adora knew she had to deal with that backline sooner or later.

If she didn't, the Horde would have enough firepower in place to overrun the position of Bow, Glimmer and General Juliet, scattering the forces of the Rebellion. It would give the Horde a straight march to Elberon, leaving all those innocent villagers at the mercy of the Horde war machine.

And it would all be Adora's fault, if she didn't do something soon.

"Glimmer!" she yelled, drawing her friend's attention and gesturing with her sword at the amassing tanks. "Get me in there!"

"Alright!" Glimmer teleported to her side, grabbing a hold of her elbow, and brought Adora right behind the tanks near the edge of the Whispering Woods. She was gone a second later, and like a well-oiled machine, Adora set to work. She cut into the first tank and bulldozed it aside with a thunderous kick, whirling around to slam her sword deep into the next one.

A red blur zipped right at Adora. She has a second to instead bring the blade up in a horizontal blocking position before Catra's claws rake across it, sending up a shower of sparks. Adora dug her foot in and pushed back, pushing Catra off the blade, who backflipping into a crouch.

"Hey, Adora," Catra hissed, drawing herself up to the full of her height.

"*Catra*," Adora replied bitterly.

And that was it. There was hardly any banter between them anymore. Catra just flew at her with a dogged, angry determination, and Adora was hard-pressed to block the swipes. She didn't always manage it anymore. More and more, Catra's claws found their mark. More and more, Adora would bleed.

She didn't especially mind it. Wounds sustained in She-Ra's form were like water off a duck's back. She just rather wished it wasn't Catra who was inflicting them.

Their fight led them away from the field of battle and deeper into the Whispering Woods, when Adora abruptly lost sight of Catra, scanning the treeline to no avail. Catra's laughter echoed around her, and Adora thought she could trace it to one of the trees. Pointing with the Sword of Protection, she unleashed a blast of energy that decimated the tree… and nobody behind it. She brought sword defensively close, turning, looking…

Something solid, red and furry slammed hard into Adora's chest, forcing Adora to take a steadying step backwards into… nothing. Finding no footing, it was all Adora could do to flail uselessly at the air before she toppled over, taking Catra with her as they both rolled downhill. Adora crabbed for a handful of Catra's hair, tunic or tail while Catra's claws scratched across her sides; even rolling to who-knows-where, they were still going at it.

The force of them hitting flat ground threw Catra off her. Adora scrambled to clamber upright, tightening her grip on her sword—

But Catra was up first. A pair of kicks to Adora's wrist and sword sent the runestone skittering across the wet grass and into the bushes. Catra caromed around, driving her heel into Adora's temple before the latter could bring her arms up. The force of it

was dizzying, and suddenly Adora felt her connection to She-Ra slipping.

"No," she moaned sluggishly. *The sword. I need the sword…*

A fourth kick straight into her face, and Adora fell over, landing not as She-Ra, Princess of Power, but as Adora, the very vulnerable and mundane mortal girl.

"Not so tough now, are you?" Catra rasped, bounding forward onto Adora's chest and pinning her down. "I thought the sword meant you were special, that you could *save* everyone, but it looks like even *that* isn't enough."

Adora blinked the stars out of her eyes, both her arms snaking out to wrap around Catra and press her close. It wasn't one of their childhood embraces, consoling one another against the harshness of the Fright Zone, but rather a bear hug intended to drive the air from Catra's lungs.

Catra snarled and kicked uselessly for a moment before dashing her forehead against Adora's. As Adora reeled from the blinding pain, Catra bit down *hard* on her chin.

"Augh, fuck!" Adora made a wild attempt at shoving her arm in Catra's face, managing to bash her elbow into the Magicat's mouth before they were disentangled from one another.

"Shit!" Catra grated, feeling at her split lip as she stumbled upright.

Adora managed to haul herself up by a nearby branch before Catra was on her again. This time Adora was ready, watching her old friend all the while, and when Catra was on her she spun with her, slamming Catra face-first into the nearby trunk. Catra's head lolled, stumbling backwards.

Adora squinted against the rain and past Catra, trying to see where the sword had slid off to. She took another step, yet Catra broke out of her daze in the next instant, her claws narrowly

missing Adora's face and then catching her behind the ear the second time.

It was one thing to get clawed up as She-Ra, but getting clawed up as *Adora* meant she received the full brunt of it, and Catra's claws could even cut through thick metal with ease. Like somebody just ripped apart a piece of paper, the side of her head was warm with blood, washed down by the rain but not stopping by any measure.

Adora managed to catch Catra's arm a second time and, not knowing what else to do, just yanked as hard as she could, sending them both falling over backwards and, lo and behold, down another short and sudden drop. Adora landed right on top of Catra, pushing at her cheeks as she tried to get up and only managing to slip in the mud onto her side. The rain kept pouring down on them, the ground long-turned to sludge and deep puddles. Catra suffered similar misfortune in getting her bearings, inadvertently kneeing Adora in the stomach and immediately falling face-first into the muck, reeling back coughing and wheezing.

They looked at one another, glaring daggers. Was it not but a year ago that they were smiling and laughing, side by side against the world?

Then Catra had a hold of her arm, her weight shifted, and they went rolling a short distance further down the slope. Adora wiped at her eyes with her bloody sleeve, dizzy and lightheaded and bleary. Catra was grabbing at her shoulders, already on her feet, but she hadn't managed to clear her vision yet, so Adora kicked at her shin and shoved aside her flailing claw. Catra slipped again, spitting and wiping at her eyes.

"Get off me, you fucking idiot!"

Adora's ankle gave out under her as she tried to rise, and then Catra was stood over her a second time, grabbing a fistful of her

torn shirt. Adora latched onto the Magicat's wrist with one hand, using the other to steady herself.

"Fuck you!" Catra growled.

"Fuck you!" Adora spat back at her.

Catra's fist crunched into the side of Adora's face, dazing her. The pain all over her body stabbed at her with every heartbeat. It was all she could do to tug hard at Catra's arm and swing a wild fist for her face, which had Catra's nose exploding in blood. Catra's grip slackened as a result, and Adora yanked again, sending her enemy collapsing gracelessly to the side.

Keeping a tight hold of Catra's wrist, Adora tried to drag herself on top and pin Catra down by the other arm as well. She clumsily missed her mark, instead shoving her palm into Catra's eye, who yelped in pained surprise. Catra's own hand smacked Adora across the face, cutting her cheek open.

"Agh!"

"Bitch!"

Adora wasn't even sure who said that. Neither was she sure anymore whether the wetness on her face was rain, blood or painful, heartbroken tears. Catra had a hold of her shirt once more, tearing her sleeve right off and losing the balance she tried to gain because of it. Adora grabbed Catra's tunic, using it as leverage to punch Catra in the face again. Catra tipped over, uttering a strangled cry of pain.

Adora was fairly certain Catra was crying too. Angry, furious tears, mixing with the rain and the thin rivulets of watered-down blood.

She made another attempt at seizing Catra's wrists, but Catra moved too fast for her, cutting Adora across the arm with a precipitous hew of her claws and shoving her down to the ground. Adora brought her knees up reflexively, and when Catra tried to straddle her she sent the Magicat staggering right over her. Catra

uttered an animalistic noise of surprise before she was sent tumbling the rest of the way down. Catra's knee caught Adora on her forehead like some sort of parting gift, flattening her to the muddy floor.

Adora lay there for a while, just riding out her hurts. No doubt Catra was in some similar predicament far down below, but right now Adora had her own woes to mind.

Still, she couldn't help but wonder why.

Why do we do this?

Why do we keep doing this?

Chapter End Notes

Work title is from Kill You by Dethklok.

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